Incident handler's journal

I keep this journal to write down what I learn from each activity, in the same format every time. Each entry says what the activity was, which tool I used and what I would remember about it.

Date	October 23, 2026
Entry	#1
Description	Documenting a cybersecurity incident
Tool(s) used	None. I worked from the incident description in the course.
The 5 W's	Who: an organized group of attackers What: a ransomware incident that encrypted the clinic's files Where: a small health care clinic When: Tuesday morning, around 9:00 a.m. Why: employees received phishing emails with a malicious attachment, and opening it gave the attackers a way in. They then ran ransomware and left a note demanding money for the decryption key, so the motive looks financial.
Additional notes	How could the clinic stop this from happening again? Training staff to spot phishing, filtering attachments on the mail server, and keeping tested offline backups would all help. Should it pay the ransom? I would not pay by default. There is no guarantee the key will work and the payment feeds the attackers. It is a decision for management, with legal advice and law enforcement, and good backups make the question less urgent.

Date	October 23, 2026
Entry	#2
Description	Reviewing a phishing alert ticket (A-2703)
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal, to look up the file hash.
The 5 W's	Who: an unknown sender using the name Clyde West, from a .su address What: a phishing email with an executable attachment called bfsvc.exe Where: the HR mailbox of the company When: Wednesday, July 20, 2022, 09:30 a.m. Why: the attacker wants the file to run on a company computer. The password written in the email is there to stop mail scanners from opening the file.
Additional notes	A hash lookup is quick and here it gave a clear answer. What I am less sure about is a file whose hash nobody has seen yet, because new malware has no reputation. For that I would need a sandbox or help from a more senior analyst.

Date	October 23, 2026
Entry	#3
Description	Comparing tcpdump and Wireshark

Tool(s) used	tcpdump and Wireshark.
Key takeaways	tcpdump is light and works on a server from the command line. Wireshark is heavier but much easier to read, with colors and filters. Both can save and read capture files, so I can capture with one and analyze with the other.
Additional notes	I need to practice the tcpdump options more. I keep forgetting which flag turns off name resolution (-nn).

Date	October 23, 2026
Entry	#4
Description	Using the Pyramid of Pain on a file hash
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal.
Key takeaways	A hash is the easiest indicator to find and the easiest for an attacker to change. Domain names and IP addresses are a bit harder to change. Tools and TTPs are the hardest, and they are the ones worth detecting.
Additional notes	Next time I look at an indicator I want to ask which level of the pyramid it sits on, and not just whether it is malicious.